Zara Shahi

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Education

Master of Fine Arts (MFA) in Fibers, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth, MA **2024–2027 (expected)**

Bachelor of Fine Arts (BFA) in Textile Design, University of Science And Culture, Tehran, Iran **2016–2020**

Professional Experience

Gallery Assistant, College of Visual & Performing Arts (CVPA), UMass Dartmouth *(Dartmouth, MA)* **2025–Present**
- Have collaborated with the gallery director on the installation and deinstallation of six exhibitions, including art handling, wall preparation, lighting, and condition reporting.
- Produce professional exhibition photography, installation views, and event documentation.
- Manage gallery social media, including content creation, exhibition promotion, and event coverage.
- Develop, coordinate, and lead hands-on workshops as part of gallery public programming.

Studio Assistant, Jonathan Michaud Studio *(Brooklyn, NY)* **2026**
- Prepared and maintained AVL looms, producing woven samples and textiles for studio projects.
- Contributed to design development and supported daily studio operations.

Teaching Assistant, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth *(Dartmouth, MA)* **2024–2025**
- Assisted students with loom setup, warping, and technical troubleshooting.
- Demonstrated weaving techniques and maintained studio equipment, materials, and organization.

Photographer, Lozee Advertising Agency *(Tehran, Iran)* **2022–2024**
- Produced photographic and visual content for social media and promotional purposes.

Printmaker, Dotan Studio *(Tehran, Iran)* **2021–2022**
- Produced hand-printed textiles, stamps, and textile designs.
- Assisted with studio operations, product preparation, and order fulfillment.

Macramé Artist & Founder, Leev Art Studio *(Tehran, Iran)* **2020–2021**
- Managed production and distribution of handmade textile products.

Textile Designer, Naghsh Negaran Pendar Company *(Tehran, Iran)* **2018–2020**
- Developed digital and hand-drawn textile patterns for interior design projects.

Residencies & Fellowships

Artist-in-Residence, New Bedford Whaling National Historical Park (U.S. National Park Service) *(New Bedford, MA)* **2026**
- Developed and presented *Unforgotten*, a multidisciplinary installation incorporating weaving, video, and sound.
- Coordinated and instructed two community weaving workshops.

Studio Assistant Fellow, Handweavers Guild of America (HGA), Convergence® Conference *(New Orleans, LA)* **2026**
- Assisted with exhibition installation and deinstallation, and supported instructors during two workshops.

Selected Commissions & Projects

Commissioned Textile Installation *(Midland, TX)* **2026**
- Designed and produced eight cross-stitched panels (24 × 20 ft total) for Millie Leigh's restaurant interior installation.

Being Seen: Celebrating SouthCoast Pride, DATMA Public Art collaboration with Lizz Collins *(New Bedford & Dartmouth, MA)* **2025**
- Contributed to concept development, design, fabrication, and installation of large-scale textile works on New Bedford City Hall and in regional galleries.

Exhibitions

Solo Exhibition

- ***Unforgotten***, New Bedford Whaling National Historical Park *(New Bedford, MA)* **2026**

Group Exhibitions

- ***Con/Struct: Images and Identity***, York College of Pennsylvania (upcoming) *(York, PA)* **2026**
- ***Still We Bloom*** *(New Bedford, MA)* **2026**
- **Handweavers Guild of America (HGA) Convergence® Conference** *(New Orleans, LA)* **2026**
- ***PhotoSpiva 2026*** (National Juried Exhibition), Spiva Center for the Arts *(Joplin, MO)* **2026**
- ***Materials: Hard + Soft*** (39th Annual International Juried Exhibition), Greater Denton Arts Council *(Denton, TX)* **2026**
- ***In Black & White***, Online Exhibition *(Site: Brooklyn)* **2025**

- ***Lighting the Star Store***, Star Store Gallery *(New Bedford, MA)* **2025**
- **UMass Dartmouth Faculty and Students Show**, Hatch Street Studios *(New Bedford, MA)* **2025**
- ***Art Current***, Kettle Black Gallery *(New Bedford, MA)* **2025**
- ***Heimtextil*** (Annual International Textiles Fair) *(Frankfurt, Germany)* **2018**
- ***The Third Step***, 4 Gallery *(Tehran, Iran)* **2018**

Teaching & Public Programming

Community Weaving Workshops, New Bedford Whaling National Historical Park *(New Bedford, MA)* **2026**
- Developed and led two public weaving workshops as an Artist-in-Residence.

Hatch Street Open Studios *(New Bedford, MA)* **2025**
- Coordinated and instructed a community weaving workshop.

Community Bracelet Weaving Workshop, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth *(Dartmouth, MA)* **2025**
- Organized and instructed a hands-on weaving workshop.

Summer Community Projects, Art & Design Studios, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth *(Dartmouth, MA)* **2025**
- Coordinated and instructed four community weaving workshops.
- Produced photographic, video, and promotional documentation.

Professional Service & Leadership

President, CVPA Fibers Club, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth **2026–Present**
- Plan and lead fiber-arts workshops, events, and showcases.
- Coordinate community outreach, collaborations, fundraising, and sales.

Orientation Leader, International Student & Scholar Center, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth **2025**
- Supported orientation programming, event logistics, student communications, and volunteer coordination.

Awards & Scholarships

Gallery Assistantship and Tuition Scholarship, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth **2025–2027**

Teaching Assistantship and Tuition Scholarship, University of Massachusetts Dartmouth **2024–2025**

Publications & Press

Fiber Art Now: Excellence in Fibers XII, Winter 2027 Issue (forthcoming) **2027**

DATMA: **Still We Bloom: Stories of Memory, Migration, and Renewal** **2026**

CAI Public Radio: **"New Bedford artist-in-residence leads community weaving project"** **2026**

Arts to Hearts Project: **"This artist uses fibre to create minimalist textile installations"** **2026**

SouthCoastToday | The Standard-Times: **New Bedford National Historical Park 2026 Artist Residency** **2026**

Arts to Hearts Magazine: Artists of the Year 2025 **2026**

Arts to Hearts Magazine: 101 Art Book: Photography Edition **2026**

Skills

Gallery & Exhibition Operations: Art handling and installation (power tools, levels, hanging hardware, vinyl lettering), deinstallation, exhibition documentation, event coordination, public programming, social media management

Digital & Technical: Professional Photography, Photoshop, Lightroom, InDesign, Illustrator, Microsoft Office Suite, WeavePoint

Art & Studio: Weaving, Textile Design, Surface Design, Printmaking, Dyeing, Papermaking, Embroidery, Ceramics, AVL Looms

Languages: English, Persian/Farsi